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Should your city turn off Facebook comments?

One of the hardest calls in local-government social media, usually made in a bad week.



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swipe →

1 in 8

You are not the only one considering it.

About one in eight city and county Facebook pages already runs with comments off. It is more common in small towns than in large governments.

GOOD REASONS TO RESTRICT

When off can be the right call

- **Coordinated harassment**
  When a small group targets staff or residents, the thread stops being a public square.
- **Health and election misinformation**
  An unmoderated thread can undercut the very announcement it sits on.
- **Staff capacity**
  A one-person shop that can't watch a thread all weekend is making a defensible call.
- **Public-records rules**
  In many states comments are records, with retention rules to follow.

BEFORE YOU FLIP THE SWITCH

Four middle paths

- **Publish a comment policy, and enforce it visibly**
  Short, content-neutral, pinned. A standard residents can point to.
- **Hide rather than delete**
  It keeps the record, which usually sits better with retention rules.
- **Restrict one post, not the page**
  Close the thread drawing abuse. Most of your posts are not the problem.
- **Use the quiet hours**
  Post contentious items when someone can actually watch the thread.

ANOTHER APPROACH, IN PRACTICE

Comments off, with a door left open.

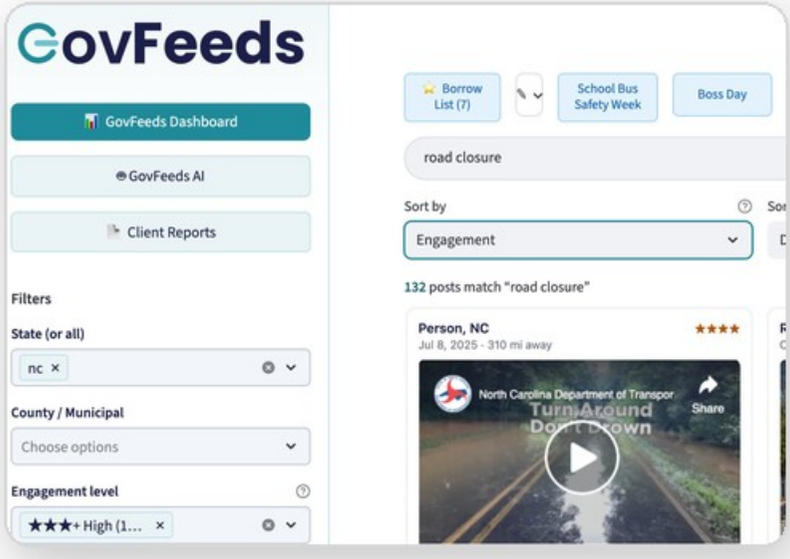


Flagler Beach, Florida closes comments on its posts and says so in every one, with an email address for comments, questions, or concerns.

DECIDE WITH EXAMPLES

See how governments like yours handle it.

Search what cities and counties actually post, including how they word comment policies and handle contentious announcements.



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